

THE SWEET SPOT

* Blue denotes PPT slide

* Brown denotes instructions to technician

TEXT: Revelation 1:1, 10-18 (NKJV) *“The Revelation of Jesus Christ, which God gave Him to show His servants—things which must shortly take place. And He sent and signified it by His angel to His servant John, ¹⁰ I was in the Spirit on the Lord’s Day, and I heard behind me a loud voice, as of a trumpet, ¹¹ saying, “I am the Alpha and the Omega, the First and the Last,” and, “What you see, write in a book and send it to the seven churches which are in Asia: to Ephesus, to Smyrna, to Pergamos, to Thyatira, to Sardis, to Philadelphia, and to Laodicea.”¹² Then I turned to see the voice that spoke with me. And having turned I saw seven golden lampstands, ¹³ and in the midst of the seven lampstands*

One like the Son of Man, clothed with a garment down to the feet and girded about the chest with a golden band. ¹⁴ His head and hair were white like wool, as white as snow, and His eyes like a flame of fire; ¹⁵ His feet were like fine brass, as if refined in a furnace, and His voice as the sound of many waters; ¹⁶ He had in His right hand seven stars, out of His mouth went a sharp two-edged sword, and His countenance was like the sun shining in its strength. ¹⁷ And when I saw Him, I fell at His feet as dead. But He laid His right hand on me, saying to me, “Do not be afraid; I am the First and the Last. ¹⁸ I am He who lives, and was dead, and behold, I am alive forevermore. Amen. And I have the keys of Hades and of Death.”

INTRO: The sweet spot is defined as “*The point or area on a bat, club, or racket at which it makes most effective contact with the ball.*”

Recently I was in Foley Alabama with my family. We went into a Krispy Kreme donut shop while the hot sign was on. When the hot sign is on, you can watch the process of the dough becoming some of the sweetest and best donuts to ever make contact with taste buds! **(PLAY KRISPY CRÈME VIDEO)**

Before the donuts become a finished product:

- The ingredients must be mixed together...
- The dough must be given time to rise...
- The dough must be rolled into one solid sheet...
- The round template must cut through the dough...
- Holes must be punched in the dough...
- The donuts must be fried to a golden brown...

This whole process must be arduously followed before the donuts are ready to have the icing applied. The icing is what we are really after, but the Krispy Kreme donut would not be up to Krispy Kreme standards without following the entire process.

All of us would like to live life in the sweet spot, but a process is required to get us there. Circumventing any part of the process is a guarantee that the purpose for our lives will be aborted and the sweet spot will probably never occur.

For the believer, the sweet spot is the place of greatest effectiveness.

I. PATMOS IS A PREREQUISITE TO THE SWEET SPOT...

The Book of Revelation was revealed to the Apostle John on an island called Patmos. He was banished there for his testimony of

Jesus. For most folks, a little dab of Patmos will do you!

The very definition of Patmos is “My killing.”

Because of its rocky, barren and desolate nature, the Roman government used the island as a place of banishment for criminals. The prisoners were compelled to work the mines of the island. The Emperor Domitian banished John to this island, about A.D. 95.

Patmos was a place of banishment for the purpose of punishment. John was not there because of any desire of his own; he was there because he was being persecuted for proclaiming the powerful message of Jesus Christ!

How interesting that God would use such a place to bring to John the Revelation of

Jesus Christ! John already knew Jesus, but his experience on Patmos was about to take their relationship to a new level.

God chooses some of the most peculiar places and circumstances to reveal the sweet spots in our lives. Are we willing to go anywhere or do anything to get in the sweet spot? How about Patmos? Are we willing to live on Patmos for God to reveal His purpose through us? Are we willing to give up our dream to pursue His?

Patmos was no picnic! Patmos is never a picnic! It means “*My Killing!*”

On Patmos, John was subject to the wicked taunts of evil and Christ-rejecting men! Men in authority had banished him to that island to make him suffer for his pricking their consciences through the preaching of the mighty Word of God!

On Patmos John was suffering, but he discovered the value of living in the patience of Jesus Christ, not his own!

II. THE SWEET SPOT CAN ONLY BE REVEALED THROUGH DIFFICULTY...

Think of the difficulty John had endured not just at Patmos, but leading up to his banishment. I am sure the devil was playing tricks in his mind with such things as:

- Where is your God now?
- Are you sure your message is right?
- If you were on target, wouldn't your God rescue you?
- Don't you think it is time to admit your mistake?

John was not only in difficulty; he was surrounded by difficult circumstances. One of the most amazing things about this passage is verse 10. ***"I was in the Spirit on the Lord's Day..."***

Despite the difficulty, John had created an atmosphere for God to reveal Himself.

I am convinced the sweet spot in life can only be revealed through difficulty. A pearl is not developed in a mall! It is developed in the life of an oyster and is the result of months, if not years, of suffering and irritation.

Most of us expend a lot of time, energy and resources attempting to avoid difficult spots altogether. For every difficult spot we are able to avoid, we run the risk of missing the icing of life and losing the opportunities that can only be discovered in the sweet spot.

(HAVE A SMALL TABLE - SOME DOUGH – A ROLLER – A CUTTER – A FRYER – AND ICING AVAILABLE TO ILLUSTRATE THIS)

At Krispi Kreme:

- The dough must be kneaded...
- The dough must be given time to rise...
- The donuts get punched out of the dough...
- The doughnuts pass through a frying process...
- Only then is the icing added...

No kneading - no time to rise - no cutting -
no frying - no sweet spot!

Nothing could have been more difficult for John than Patmos, but listen to his words: “*I was in the Spirit on the Lord’s Day.*” Not only was John in the Spirit on the Lord’s Day, He received revelation that no one before or after him ever received. In fact the revelation was so strong that he described portions of it as “*not lawful to utter.*”

When we can bring ourselves to trust God enough to bravely walk into a personal

Patmos, we will likely see a greater revelation of Jesus through our lives than we could have anticipated.

Sometimes:

- Rejection is protection...
- Division is multiplication...
- Separation is preparation...
- Mortification is fortification...
- Dejection determines destiny...
- Disappointment is really the appointment...

When walking through a personal Patmos, if we create an atmosphere for God to move, we will see miraculous things take place! We will see Him in His glory!

III. THE SWEET SPOT IS WHERE GOD'S POWER IS REVEALED...

At Patmos, John saw Jesus! Patmos sure didn't look like a sweet spot. But for John, Jesus took the stick of life and pushed him

under the avalanche of icing, right into the sweet spot!

ILLUSTRATION:

(Use a stick to push a couple people around - into the sweet spot of life)

Admiral Jim Stockdale who spent eight years in the Hanoi Hilton (POW Camp) said, *“What separates people is not the presence or absence of difficulty but how they deal with the inevitable difficulties of life.”*

Most of us never get to a place where God can get through to us without a personal Patmos! Oftentimes the only way we can receive a true, first-hand revelation from God is to be pushed out of our comfort zone. We need to quit struggling against the stick of life and accept what comes our way with contentment. [Philippians 4:11](#) (NKJV) *“I have learned in whatever state I am, to be content.”*

The difficulty we face could very easily be the stick of life being held by a nail-scarred hand attempting to push us under the avalanche of icing!

As close as John was to Jesus, it was only at Patmos that John saw Jesus on a completely different level. [Revelation 1:17](#) (NKJV)

“When I saw Him, I fell at His feet as dead.” John had never responded to Jesus in this way before! The stick of life pushed John under the avalanche of icing on Patmos.

CONCLUSION:

In the sweet spot called Patmos, John wrote the last few chapters of the Bible and they stand in stark contrast to the first few books of the Bible:

- Genesis speaks of the creation of the sun
 - Revelation tells of a place that needs no sun

- Genesis speaks of the entrance of sin into this world - Revelation tells of the banishment of all sin
- Genesis speaks of the curse of sin that is pronounced upon mankind - Revelation declares the curse of sin to be broken
- Genesis speaks of Satan's first triumphant victory over mankind - Revelation speaks of Satan's demise
- Genesis speaks of the exclusion from the Tree of Life - Revelation speaks of the admission to the Tree of Life

If we want to live in the sweet spot we must be willing to:

- Patiently endure hardships...
- Be content in all circumstances...
- Be willing to get shoved around a little...
- Walk in the Spirit in spite of all circumstances...

PLACES PREACHED:

CT Church Houston TX July 28 – August 11
2013

Bridge Church Cabot AR 8/18/13